dose is administered. This is presently followed throughout our country to protect children from permanent blindness caused due to vitamin A deficiency.

Pregnant women should take nutritious food that contains vitamin A. This helps the child in the womb to get vitamin A from its mother.

Recipes rich in vitamin A suitable for children

Boiled egg, egg custard, coriander and mint chutney with bread / chapathi, carrot halwa, carrot salad, carrot kheer, carrot juice, papaya, orange juice, tomato juice, mango juice, palak dal, palak paneer.

3.2 Nutrition for School Children (6-12 years)

The school- age period has been called the latent time of growth. School-age children grow significantly, but at slower rate, and are physically very active in general. As a result, their nutritional needs are high and critical.

Maintaining a balanced diet and regular exercise is important for school-aged children (6-12 years). These children are required to eat a variety of foods from each food group to ensure optimal intake of all vitamins and minerals. At the same time, they may face new challenges regarding food choices and habits. Decisions about what to eat are partly determined by the influences from friends at school and the media, especially television.

3.2.1 Nutritional requirements of School children

Poor nutrition not only compromises the quality of life of school-aged children but also their potential to benefit from education. Adequate nutrition of school aged children will also ensure that they grow to their full potential, and provide the stepping stones to a healthy life.

The RDA of school children aged 7-12 years suggested by ICMR is given in Table 3.2

Table 3.2 ICMR recommended dietary allowances for school children

Nutrient	Years		
	7-9	10-12	
		Boys	Girls
Weight (Kg)	25.1	34.3	35.0
Energy (kcal)	1690	2190	2010
Protein (g)	29.5	39.9	40.4
Fat (g)	30	35	35
Calcium (mg)	600	800	800
Iron (mg)	16	21	27
Vitamin A (µg)	600	600	600
Beta carotene (µg)	4800	4800	4800
Thiamine (mg)	0.8	1.1	1.0
Riboflavin (mg)	1.0	1.3	1.2
Nicotinic acid (mg)	13	15	13
Pyridoxine (mg)	1.6	1.6	1.6
Ascorbic acid (mg)	40	40	40
Folic acid (µg)	120	140	140
Vitamin B12(µg)	0.2-1.0	0.2-1.0	0.2-1.0

Source: Dietary Guidelines for Indians - A Manual by Kamala Krishnaswamy, B. Sesikeran (Second Edition 2011) , NIN, ICMR

Nutritional requirements of boys and girls are more or less the same till the first 9 years. After that, there is a variation in some nutrients.

The essential nutrients for optimal health during school age are:

Energy

Energy needs vary with the child's growth rate, body size and physical activity. The mean increase in body weight is 2.5-2.7 kg/ year. During periods of rapid growth, appetite increases and children tend to eat constantly. The brain needs energy to function properly and hence a constant supply of glucose is critical. Cognitively demanding tasks, such as schoolwork, require regular supplies of glucose to the brain in order to enhance

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